



△ INSIDE THE MOSQUE

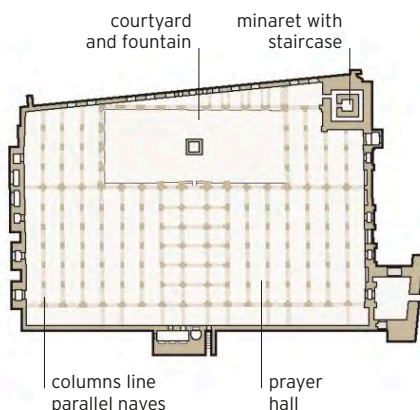
The interior walls of the mosque are painted plain white, contrasting with the colorful mats that carpet the floors. Non-Muslim tourists have never seen this sight, as the building is open only to Muslim worshippers.

◁ NIGHT BEACON

Standing tall behind the food stalls of the bustling Jemaa el-Fna square, in the heart of old Marrakech, the mosque's distinctive minaret is lit up at night. It is visible from a distance of 18 miles (29 km).

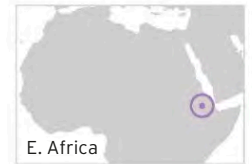
COLUMNED HALL

The sandstone walls of the mosque enclose a courtyard created around a fountain and a large prayer hall. Measuring about 58,000 square ft (5,400 square m) in area, the hall is divided into a series of parallel naves by 112 columns supporting horseshoe-shaped arches. The minaret stands at the northeast corner of the building.



Lalibela Rock Churches

Orthodox Christian churches carved from solid rock in the mountains of Ethiopia



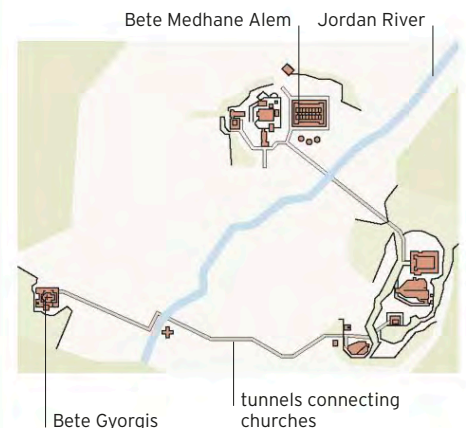
The 11 rock churches at Lalibela in the Amhara district of northern Ethiopia were probably built by King Gebre Meskel Lalibela, after whom the town is named. A member of the Zagwe dynasty, he ruled this mountainous area of Ethiopia about 900 years ago. A devout Christian of the Ethiopian Orthodox faith, he is said to have created the churches in response to the fall of Jerusalem to a Muslim army in 1187, intending the complex as a recreation of the holy city.

Exceptional technique

Each of the churches was made by chiseling away soft, reddish volcanic rock to isolate a rectangular block. The workers then cut inward, hollowing the block to form a room inside. The largest church, Bete Medhane Alem, has rows of outer columns like a Greek temple. Bete Gyorgis, the best preserved, is in the shape of a cross. Designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1978, the churches are a living place of pilgrimage visited by thousands of worshippers each day.

NEW JERUSALEM

The layout of the Lalibela churches was intended as a symbolic representation of Jerusalem. The river that crosses the site is called the Jordan, after the river that flows through parts of the Holy Land. The principal groups of churches are connected by tunnels. Bete Gyorgis stands separate, allegedly added to the scheme after St. George appeared to King Lalibela in a dream.



▽ STANDING TALL

Bete Gyorgis, or the Ethiopian Coptic Church of St. George, is about 40 ft (12 m) tall. Twelve windows are cut through an upper story, perhaps representing the 12 Apostles of Christ.

